

Transliteration

The easiest way to write a message in a regional language is to type out the words using the English alphabet. For example, *Aap kaise hain?* (How are you?). Sites that offer the facility of sending e-mail in regional languages will then convert this message into the vernacular script.

This process of converting characters from one particular script to another is called transliteration. In our case, it would be the conversion of the English (also known as Roman or Latin) script to Hindi or Telugu or another regional language script, and vice versa. It should be clearly understood that transliteration is not the same as translation. In transliteration, only the characters are converted to another script. There is a strong possibility that factors such as pronunciation, meanings, accents, etc., would change if transliteration methods are not properly designed and used.

A transliteration can either be applied to a string of text in one go, or can be used incrementally for a typing and buffered output. For example, let's consider that you want to have the word 'Hello' transliterated to Hindi. For the Hindi equivalent, you may have to type in 'Helau'. This is the string of characters that gives the Hindi script equivalent of Hello after transliteration. Different transliteration schemes have different string combinations.

Most transliteration schemes work reasonably well with Hindi, but are not as efficient with other regional languages.

Jagran—Hindi special

In case you need to send only Hindi e-mail, check out this site. www.jagran.com offers the option of sending mail only in English or Hindi. Registration is simple. The page will look unreadable when you log on for the first time, but this is rectified after you download the required fonts by selecting the option, Download Hindi Font, and then installing it.

One option for sending e-mail in Hindi using Jagran is the Phonetic Style, which is the same as transliteration and allows you to type the letter in Hindi using English equivalents. You could check the Show/Hide keyboard option when you're composing a Hindi e-mail. This brings up a Hindi keyboard below the mail being composed. Positioning the cursor on each alphabet will give you the English equivalent of the Hindi alphabet. Above the Hindi keyboard is a dynamic guide showing the different Hindi equivalents based on the first alphabet you type.

Langoo.com—a global view

If you're looking for something more than just an Indian language e-mail site, you must visit www.langoo.com. This US-based site offers an impressive array of Indian and foreign languages. In addition to Indian languages such as Hindi, Tamil, etc, langoo.com also features Chinese, French, Arabic, Russian, Greek and a whole host of other languages. This is one of the best sites for sending regional language messages and the options offered are sure to make you linger on at the site to check them all out.

You can even chat and send e-cards in your



Langoo.com: view it in the language you want

native language (provided, of course, it's supported by the site). In fact, the whole site can be viewed in your native language instead of in English.

The best part about Langoo is that it does not require you to install any new fonts, and using it is child's play. The language can be changed at your whim. Hindi, Punjabi, Tamil, Farsi, Gujarati and Urdu are the Indian languages currently available on Langoo. A help list on English character equivalents for the regional language characters is available under the text box where you type in your message. This is a very useful feature when compared to epatra and rediff, where the alphabet usage lists appear only when you type in the first alphabet.

So what are you waiting for? Select your language, register, and start Langooing.

Get that Epatra Going

Click on the Sign Up link on the home page to get the registration form.

Fill in the form and click the 'Register me' button at the bottom of the page. This takes you to the next page along with a prompt, asking if you want to download and install HlInstall.exe. Click on the 'Run program from current location' option and press OK. The font will be automatically installed on your system.



Inbox. Select the Compose option on the left-hand side of the page to start composing your e-mail.

Now go to the bottom of the Web page and log on using your password. This takes you to the



Select the language in which you want to write your e-mail. Click Go,

and start typing your mail.

As you type the first letter of an alphabet, a help table pops up,



showing the correct combination of English characters required to get the desired regional language character.